

On the morphosyntax of Spanish (object) relative clauses

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This paper discusses the syntax of Spanish restrictive subject and object relative clauses, focusing on the categorial status of the relative element *que*. Specifically, I extend the influential account of Poletto & Sanfelici (2018) to Spanish, proposing a unified analysis of *que* in terms of a Wh-determiner. In examining the morphosyntactic implications of this hypothesis, I further argue that a single *que* exists that can realise different portions of the same underlying structure, based on a spanning-like derivation *à la* Svenonius (2012; 2016; 2020).

1. Introduction

Linguistic theory has long been concerned with relative clauses. Over the years, an incredibly large number of contributions have offered many different analyses of these structures. What is probably at the base of such proliferation is the fact that relative clauses come in disparate types, both intra- and interlinguistically. Research on this topic has traditionally focused on defining the syntax underlying different relativisation strategies, with the aim of unifying their intricate variation under a single analysis. Central to this is the definition of the categorial status of relativisers, or more generally, all elements that introduce relative clauses. Essentially, scholars have debated whether and which such elements should be treated as complementisers or relative pronouns. This paper contributes to this debate by examining the specific case of Spanish subject and object relative clauses. In particular, I propose a unified analysis of *que* as a wh-determiner, extending for the first time to Spanish a prominent analysis that has been proposed for many other Romance languages (cf. Section 4). In doing so, I also review other salient morphosyntactic properties of Spanish relative clauses and show how they can all be derived in a uniform fashion based on up-to-date syntactic assumptions. These properties include i) the variation in the position of the subject in object relative clauses, and ii) the alternation between bare *que* and *al/a la que*. As far as the latter is concerned, I argue that a single *que* exists that can realise different portions of the same underlying structure, calling upon Spanning theory (Svenonius 2012, 2016, 2020).

The paper is organised as follows: Section 2 reviews the main analyses of relative clauses in syntactic theory, with a focus on their derivations; Section 3 illustrates the word order properties of Spanish relative clauses and how to interpret them syntactically, while Section 4 describes the morphosyntactic variation of *que*. In Section 5 I present my analysis. Section 6 concludes.

2. Relative clauses in syntactic theory

A relative clause is, at its simplest, a clause that modifies a noun. Traditionally, two major types have been distinguished: *restrictive relative clauses* and *non-restrictive relative clauses*. The former limit the meaning of the noun they modify, *restricting* the identification of its referent to the intersection of the denotations of the relative clause and the head noun. For instance, in *The tree that John planted is a spruce* the relative clause specifies the referent of the noun as the one tree that John planted. On the other hand, non-restrictive, or *appositive* relative clauses do not intersect with the denotation of the noun, but rather provide additional independent information, as in *The tree, which is a spruce, was planted by John*. In semantic terms, restrictive relative clauses behave like other intersective modifiers such as adjectives and predicates, and are described as being of type $\langle e, t \rangle$ (Heim & Kratzer 1998; Zimmermann & Sternefeld 2013). In contrast, non-restrictive relative clauses are seemingly closer to an independent sentence of type t that follows the noun, as in e.g. *The tree was planted by John. The tree is a spruce* (Ross 1967; Demirdache 1991; Trabandt 2016). In this paper I will be only concerned with restrictive relative clauses and, among these, only subject relative clauses and object relative clauses. I will thus leave aside oblique relative clauses and non-restrictive relative clauses altogether.

At the syntactic level, relative clauses have been at the centre of a fertile debate, giving rise to numerous analyses over the years. In spite of some inevitable idiosyncratic aspects that differentiate single proposals, these can be grouped into three main sets of theories, namely so-called head-external analyses, matching analyses, and raising analyses. These offer (partially) different solutions to what Salzmann (2017) describes as the *connectivity problem* and the *modification problem*. Concretely, any analysis of relative clauses ought to address two issues. First, the grammatical definition of the link between the surface position of the head noun and the RC-internal position to which it is related (connectivity problem). Second, the location where the relative clause attaches to the noun it modifies, and the type of syntactic relation that is established between the two (modification problem). The following subsection briefly illustrates the main characteristics of head-external analyses, matching analyses, and raising analyses, and how these deal with said issues.

2.1. Head external analysis, matching analysis, and raising analysis

In the head external analysis, the head noun is not represented inside the relative clause (RC), and a relative operator or a (c)overt pronoun is A'-moved to the C-domain, where it is co-indexed with the external head noun (cf. Plann 1975; Montague 1973; Chomsky 1977; Jackendoff 1977; Boef 2012), as in (1).

- (1) I like the woman [_{CP} whom₁/Op₁ C_{rel} John kissed ____₁]. (Salzmann 2017:39)

This type of analysis was extensively adopted throughout the Government and Binding era but

later gave way to accounts that posit a representation of the head noun internal to the RC. Indeed, many have regarded such an alternative as superior in many respects. First and foremost, it seems better equipped to analyse the rich typology of relativisation strategies, which includes head-internal RCs (cf. Alexiadou et al. 2000; de Vries 2002; Salzmann 2017; Cinque 2020). Moreover, assuming a RC-internal representation of the head noun offered a more natural interpretation to a number of properties largely (but not only) related to reconstruction effects. For instance, the fact that certain expressions keep their idiomatic meaning when split between the RC and the matrix clause suggests that the head noun forms a constituent with the RC verb at some stage of the derivation. One such classic example is the one presented by Schachter (1973) and Vergnaud (1974) for French, where the interpretation of the idiom chunk *tirer parti* ‘to take advantage’ keeps intact when *parti* is the head of the RC:

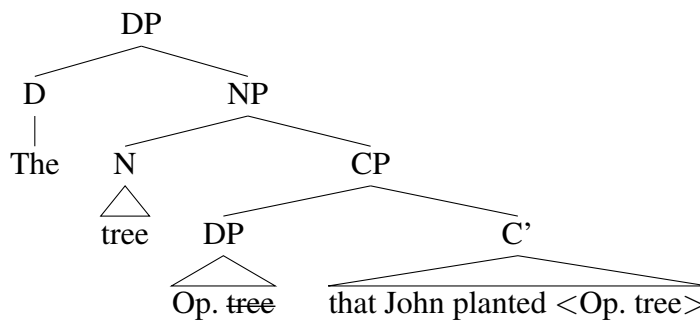
- (2) *Peu de gens ont parlé du parti qu’il a tiré des difficultés économiques.*
 few of people have spoken of-the advantage that-he has taken of-the difficulties
 economic
 ‘Few people have talked about the advantage that he took from the economic crisis.’
 (From Perpiñán 2010:37)

Again, under the assumption that the idiomatic meaning can only be assigned when the verb and its argument (here *tirer* and *parti*) form a constituent, it follows that the head noun in (1) must have occupied the complement position within the RC predicate structure at some point. A somewhat similar case is that of binding effects, and notably Principle A effects (Schachter 1973; Kayne 1994). Consider the sentence in (3). If the relative head *picture of himself* were generated in a position external to the RC, at no point in the derivation could the anaphor *himself* be c-commanded by its antecedent (*John*).

- (3) *the picture of himself_i that John_i likes__ best* (Salzmann 2017:2)

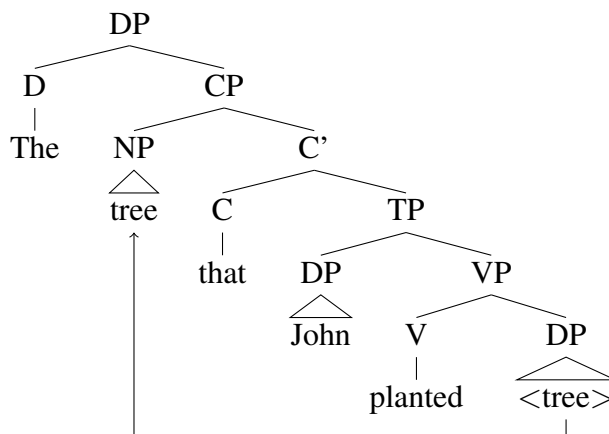
The actual interpretation of (3) is thus only obtained if *picture of himself* is reconstructed within the RC as the internal argument of the verb *like*. After a fashion, both (3) and (2) imply that the head noun can be interpreted as part of the RC predicate. To secure this scenario, the head noun must have a RC-internal representation, which is exactly what constitutes the premises of both matching and raising analyses.

While its original formulations can be traced back to the early 60s (Lees 1960, 1961; Chomsky 1965), the matching analysis has only garnered a renewed consensus in recent years (Sauerland 1998, 2003, 2004; Citko 2001; Salzmann 2006 a.o.). At its core, the matching approach posits that the head noun is represented twice: once in its surface position (i.e., the matrix clause), and once within the RC, as illustrated in (4).

(4) *Matching derivation*

In this derivation, the RC-internal instance of the head noun moves along with a relative operator to the left periphery of the RC. From there, it gets deleted by its non-distinct, c-commanding copy in the matrix clause, so that only the latter is phonetically realised (Sauerland 2003, 2004).

Conversely, in raising analyses there is a single instance of the head noun. This is base-generated within the RC and then moved (or *raised*) to the CP-layer of the RC (e.g. Kayne 1994; Cinque 2008, 2020) or, in some versions, up to a higher projection in the complement position of the external DP (e.g. Bhatt 2002; Donati & Cecchetto 2011; Cecchetto & Donati 2015). This approach finds its roots in works by Brame (1968), Schachter (1973), and Vergnaud (1974), though likely owes its popularity to Kayne's (1994) influential re-elaborated version, upon which all recent analyses are based (Bianchi 1999, 2000, 2002; Cinque 2008, 2020; Poletto & Sanfelici 2018 a.o.). The tree in (5) illustrates a typical raising derivation.

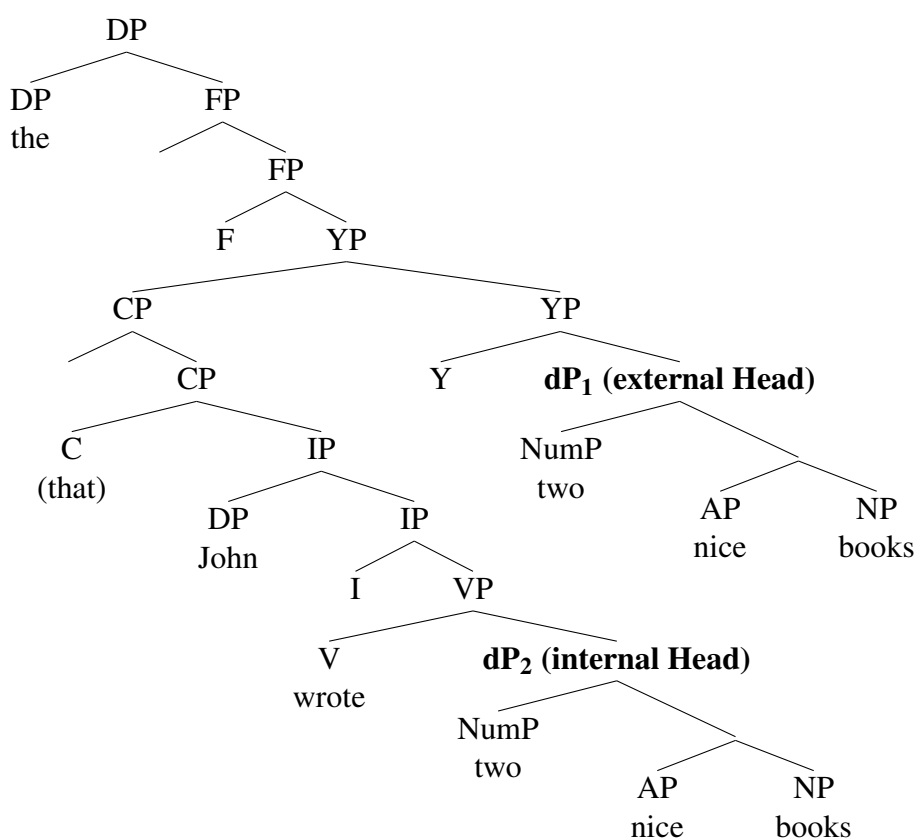
(5) *Raising derivation*

On closer inspection, however, neither matching nor raising derivations are completely immune to criticism. One major aspect that raising accounts tend to leave somewhat unaddressed is the fact that the head noun potentially receives two conflicting theta roles and cases.¹ At the same time, a genuine matching approach is not always fully equipped to accommodate cases like (1), where idioms are seemingly split between the matrix clause and the RC. It is not my purpose to delve into all the arguments and counterarguments of either approach, for which I refer to the comprehensive review of the topic in Salzmann (2017). I will rather limit myself to acknowledging that many scholars have proposed that both raising and matching derivations are

¹ See Kayne (1994:ch:8) and Bianchi (1999) for possible solutions.

supported by substantial evidence, suggesting that they are in principle equally available to UG (Áfarli 1994; Aoun & Li 2003; Sauerland 2003, 2004; Hulsey & Sauerland 2006; Szczegielniak 2004; Cinque 2008, 2020). This is why, when confronted with the vast array of options for analysing Spanish RCs, I opted for a syntactic structure that accommodates both types of derivations, following Cinque (2008, 2011, 2020). Cinque pursues the idea that matching and raising approaches are not mutually-exclusive but, rather, structural variants that emerge from one and the same ‘double-headed’ underlying structure. A representation of the latter is given in (6), where the RC is, much as other pre-nominal modifiers, attached to the functional spine of the external head noun, in accord with standard cartographic assumptions (Cinque & Rizzi 2009; Rizzi 2013b) and Kayne’s LCA (Kayne 1994).

(6) *Double-headed RC structure* (adapted from Cinque 2020)



Cinque’s (2020) book extensively discusses how this base structure adapts to the needs of typologically diverse RC-configurations. In particular, it shows that, depending on the properties of the RC/language at issue, either type of analysis is available. In a matching derivation, the external head moves above the attachment-site of the internal head and deletes it (Cinque 2020:18). In a raising derivation, the external head stays put, while ‘*it is the Head internal to the relative clause that ends up being the overt Head by raising to Spec,CP and licensing the deletion of the external Head*’ (Cinque 2020:16).

In the next sections I will take into account the specific case of Spanish subject and object RCs and, after discussing some relevant properties of the relative *que*, show how these can be analysed based on a (slightly modified version of) double-headed structure *à la* Cinque.

3. Spanish RCs - word order

Like all Romance languages (as well as English and Germanic languages), Spanish has head-external, post-nominal RCs.² The sentences in (7) and (8) show an example of, respectively, subject RC (henceforth SRC) and object RC (henceforth ORC).

- (7) La chica que mira a la profesora es Isabel.
 the girl that watches DOM the professor is Isabel
 ‘The girl looking at the teacher is Isabel.’
- (8) La chica que la profesora mira es Isabel.
 the girl that the professor watches is Isabel
 ‘The girl the teacher is looking at is Isabel.’

Moreover, ORCs can vary with respect to the position of the subject within the RC. Subjects can appear pre-verbally, as seen in (8), but also post-verbally, like in (9).³

- (9) La chica que mira la profesora es Isabel.
 the girl that watches the professor is Isabel
 ‘The girl the teacher is looking at is Isabel.’

Gutiérrez-Bravo (2005) proposed that, unlike in the matrix clause, the unmarked word order in Spanish ORCs requires a post-verbal subject, thus resulting in OVS word order. He further maintains that subjects occurring in that position are foci conveying new information, while pre-verbal subjects rather constitute topics related to old information. Moreover, he observes that the alternation between OVS and OSV orders is not just regulated by the information-theoretical structure. In fact, there seems to be a crucial interaction with factors related to the prosodic weight and intonational prominence of the phonological phrases that are involved. In essence, given that the nuclear accent in Spanish is always clause-final (Contreras 1976; Zubizarreta 1998) and that subjects, as stressed lexical heads, constitute the head of the phonological phrase in which they occur (here the RC), these must follow the verb (i.e. a lighter phonological phrase) as in (9).⁴ When such a prosodic configuration is altered, however, the subject realises in its canonical pre-verbal position, as is the case in RCs with two complements, about which ‘*speakers have clear intuitions that the unmarked position of the subject is not the post-verbal position, but rather the canonical pre-verbal position*’ (Gutiérrez-Bravo 2005:160):

- (10) *Qué pasó?* ‘What happened?’
- a. # Estoy leyendo la carta que le mandó la maestra a Pedro.
 am reading the letter that DAT-CL sent the teacher to Pedro
 ‘I am reading the letter that the teacher sent to Pedro.’

² See Bianchi (2002); Salzmann (2017); De Vries (2018); Cinque (2020) for a complete review of RC-types.

³ Note that this sentence is not ambiguous with a SRC reading. Had (9) been a SRC, the RC-internal DP (*la profesora*) should have been introduced by DOM. Because DOM is missing here, the only available reading is the ORC one. See Presotto & Torregrossa (2024) (forth.) for a discussion.

⁴ One crucial assumption here is that much as there are light and heavy syllables at the word level (Prince 1990; Hayes 1995; Ryan 2016), there are also light and heavy prosodic phrases at the level of sentence prosody (Gutiérrez-Bravo 2005:156-157).

- b. Estoy leyendo la carta que la maestra le mandó a Pedro.
 am reading the letter that the teacher DAT-CL sent to Pedro
 ‘I am reading the letter that the teacher sent to Pedro.’

(Gutiérrez-Bravo 2005:160)

In the above examples, because the accent falls on the indirect object (a heavy phonological phrase), the subject can freely occur pre-verbally without interfering with conflicting prosodic requirements.⁵ As the author put it, Spanish can thus be characterised as a ‘*a language that prioritizes intonational considerations over canonical subject position*’, which is, he continues, ‘*not surprising*’ (Gutiérrez-Bravo 2005:157), as similar contingencies can be found elsewhere in the language, for instance with narrow-focused subjects in matrix clauses (cf. Büring & Gutiérrez-Bravo 2001). As a matter of fact, these observations seem to find further support in languages that share similar prosodic properties.⁶ In Italian, for instance, subjects in ORCs are typically realised post-verbally in out-of-the-blue contexts (11a). Much as in Spanish, though, a pre-verbal subject is preferred when additional (heavy) phonological material is added after the verb. This could be an argument, as the indirect object in (11b), an adjunct (11c), or even just a single adverb (11d).

(11) *Che fai?* ‘What are you doing?’

- a. Sto leggendo la lettera che ha mandato la maestra.
 am reading the letter that has sent the teacher
 ‘I am reading the letter that the teacher sent.’
- b. Sto leggendo la lettera che la maestra ha mandato a Pietro.
 am reading the letter that the teacher has sent to Pietro
 ‘I am reading the letter that the teacher sent to Peter.’
- c. Ho incontrato la maestra che Pietro ha disegnato nel suo diario.
 have.1SG met the teacher that Pietro has drawn in.the his diary
 ‘I met the teacher who Peter has drawn in his journal.’
- d. Ho incontrato la maestra che Pietro ha disegnato ieri.
 have.1SG met the teacher that Pietro has drawn yesterday
 ‘I met the teacher who Peter has drawn yesterday.’

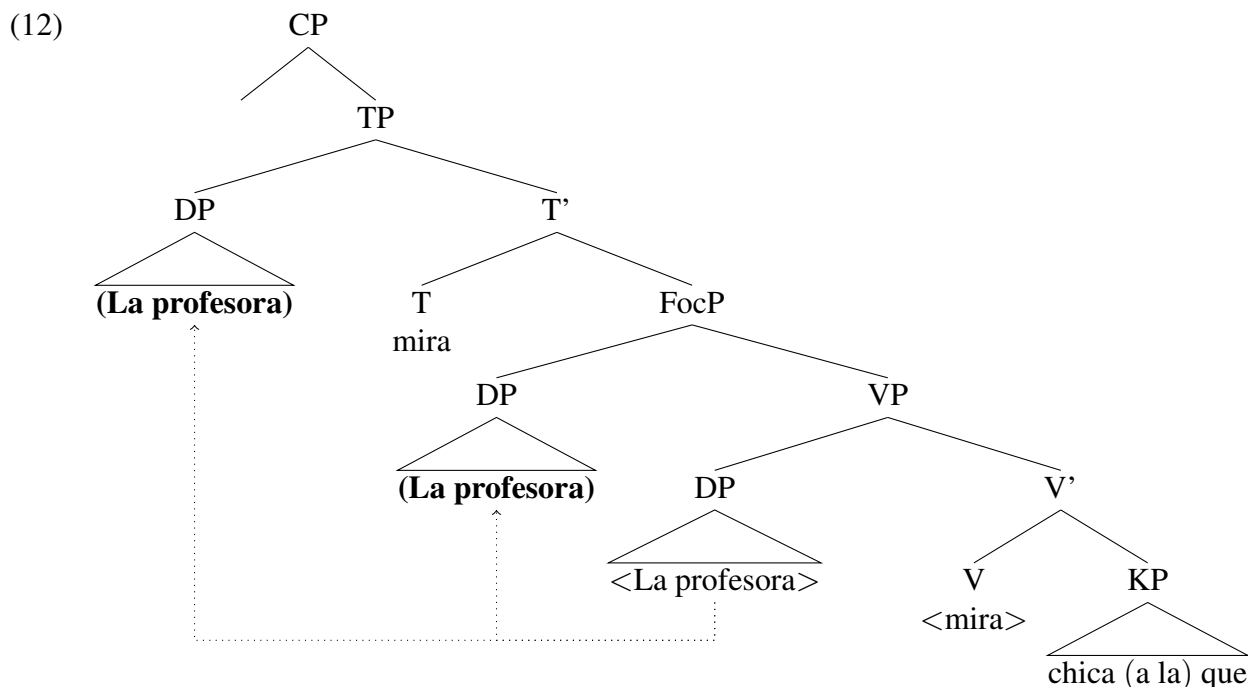
Steady though these contrasts are in Italian, I would not go as far as suggesting that acceptability is ever deeply compromised based solely on subject position. In all displayed cases, both pre- and post-verbal subjects are in fact fully grammatical. This apparently holds true also for Spanish, where the position of the subject does not alter the interpretation of the sentence, nor does either order characterise as non acceptable.⁷ In sum, barring said prosodic restrictions, pre- and post-verbal subjects in Spanish ORCs are largely interchangeable and, as far as their syntax

⁵ The conflict between syntactic and prosodic requirements is handled by Gutiérrez-Bravo (2005) within an Optimality Theory approach (cf. Prince & Smolensky 2004 and Gutiérrez-Bravo 2005:157-164).

⁶ Italian, in particular, is especially close to Spanish in this respect. On top of assigning the nuclear accent to the rightmost constituent (Calabrese 1982; Bocci & Cruschina 2018 a.o.), Italian is, like Spanish, a so-called *stress accent* language, which modulates metrical prominence based on a series of spectral cues such as fundamental frequency (f0), intensity, and duration (D’Imperio 2002).

⁷ In this respect, see Betancort et al. (2009:1918), Brown & Rivas (2011:23), del Río et al. (2012:2111), Ezeizabarrena (2012:2-3), and Sagarra et al. (2019:123-124).

is concerned, can be reasonably analysed in a fairly standard fashion. Specifically, I argue that pre-verbal subjects occupy the Spec,TP position, and post-verbal subjects a low Spec,FocP *à la* Belletti (2004), as illustrated in the following tree.⁸



4. Spanish RCs - DOM and the status of que

A second source of variation in Spanish ORCs relates to the (non-)realisation of DOM in front of the relative particle *que*. As is well known, Spanish marks a specific class of direct objects with the particle *a*, a case-like marker homophonous with the dative preposition that is frequently referred to as A-marker (Rodríguez-Mondoñedo 2007). In the main clause, at least [human, specific, definite] direct objects are obligatorily A-marked, and the absence of DOM results in ungrammaticality:⁹

- (13) La profesora mira **(a)* la chica.
 the teacher looks DOM the girl
 ‘The teacher is looking at the girl.’

In ORCs, however, the marking of the head noun is not as straightforward. In fact, even when the head noun is [human, specific, definite], the realisation of DOM (in conjunction with the definite article *ella*) is optional (cf. Sagarra et al. 2019:123):

- (14) a. la chica a la que la profesora mira
 the girl DOM the that the teacher looks
 ‘the girl that the teacher is looking at’

⁸ I discuss in greater detail the other relevant steps of the derivation in the following section.

⁹ For a comprehensive review of the topic see Bossong (1991); Torrego (1998); Aissen (2003); Leonetti (2008); Rodríguez-Mondoñedo (2008); López (2012); Fábregas (2013).

- b. la chica que la profesora mira
 the girl that the teacher looks
 ‘the girl that the teacher is looking at’

To better understand why ORCs seem to allow different conditions on the morphological realisation of DOM, it is worth taking a closer look at the relative particle *que*.

Defining the nature of *que* is not an easy task. Ever since seminal work by Klima (1964), Kayne (1975), and Radford (1981), a prolific strand of research has been concerned with the definition of the categorial status of relative elements. Central to this debate is the question whether these are subordinating heads, like clausal complementisers, or rather relative pronouns. Fortunately, a well-established set of attributes help us distinguishing the two. As reported in (15), indeed, complementisers and relative pronouns/wh-words behave differently with respect to three main properties.

- (15) a. Case marking: complementisers do not inflect for case, relative pronouns can
 b. Sensitivity to animacy: complementisers do not encode animacy features, relative pronouns can
 c. Compatibility with prepositions: complementisers cannot be combined with prepositions, relative pronouns can

If we take English, for instance, we can distinguish *that* from *who* and *which* based on these properties. *That* does not inflect for case (16a) *who* can (16b). Similarly, *that* cannot pied-pipe a preposition (17a), while both *whom* and *which* can (17b,c). Finally, whereas *that* is not sensitive to animacy, *who* can only be used with animate head nouns (18).

- (16) a. the boy that you like/likes you
 b. the boy who/whom you like
- (17) a. * the girl about that I told you
 b. the girl about whom I told you
 c. the car about which I told you
- (18) the car that/*who Jenna bought

For these reasons, *that* has been traditionally assigned the status of relative complementiser (or relativiser) and *who/which* that of wh-words. But what about Spanish? Well, as all Romance languages, Spanish has a fairly wider paradigm of relative elements. This includes full-fledged relative pronouns like e.g. *el/la cual*; *los/las cuales*,¹⁰ as well as elements like *que*, whose nature is not as immediately captured. A good starting point to determine its status is, once again, observing how *que* behaves with respect to the properties in (15). Let us start with the third one, namely the possibility to occur with prepositions in pied-piping configurations. The sentence in (19) illustrates that *que* can be preceded by, for instance, the preposition *en*, indicating that in this respect *que* patterns with wh-words rather than relativisers.

- (19) la casa en que Juan vivió
 the house in that Juan lived
 ‘the house where Juan lived’

¹⁰ See Zagana (2001:58-60) for a review.

The other two properties concern case-marking and sensitivity to animacy. In a way, the example presented in (14a) already provides evidence suggesting that *que* is somehow responsive to both. By definition, the A-marker encodes (also) animacy and case features. More precisely, it has been interpreted as an accusative marker that applies to animate (and definite, specific, ...) direct objects (Brugè & Brugger 1996; Aissen 2003; Leonetti 2004; Rodríguez-Mondoñedo 2007; Fábregas 2013). Hence, the sheer fact that *que* can be preceded by DOM is sufficient to say that even with regard to case and animacy, *que* shows characteristics typical of wh-words. Additional support in this direction comes from oblique RCs like those in (20). Under the assumption that *cuyas* corresponds to the genitive inflection of *que*, and *quien* to its animate form, we can further emphasise how *que* shows behaviours typical of *bona fide* relative pronouns.

- (20) a. la casa cuyas ventanas son verdes
 the house whose windows are green
 ‘the house whose windows are green’
 b. el profesor/*libro con quien he estudiado
 the professor/book with that/animate AUX-have.1SG studied
 ‘the book with which I studied’

If we take Klima tests seriously (cf. the list in 15), these few examples speak for themselves and intimate that *que* is a wh-word and not a relativiser.¹¹ Regardless, the literature on this subject has not reached a uniform consensus and, in fact, some analyses come to different conclusions. I briefly review in the next paragraph the two most prominent analyses of Spanish *que*. After that, I will present my own proposal.

4.1. The ‘bare que hypothesis’ and the ‘unique que hypothesis’

Suñer (2000) proposed that *que* is a wh-pronoun, but not when it introduces a SRC or an ORC, in which cases it rather characterises as a complementiser. This analysis is known as the ‘bare *que* hypothesis’. Alternative to that is the so-called ‘unique *que* hypothesis’ proposed by Brucart (1992), which assumes that *que* is always a complementiser, independently of the type of RC in which it occurs. The main piece of evidence in support of Brucart’s approach comes from some Canarian and Puerto Rican sentences like *La amiga con la [más confianza] que tengo* (‘The friend I trust the most’), where *que* does not seem to form a constituent with the preposition and the determiner following the head noun. This is readily accounted for if *que* is in the C head, while it becomes more problematic if *que* is analysed as a wh-word. Note, however, that this type of sentences are not allowed in standard Peninsular Spanish. Moreover, Suñer (2000) does not consider these cases to be genuine counter-evidence against a relative pronoun analysis of *que*, as they are probably instances of misanalysis by analogy with other similar structures.¹²

The ‘unique *que* hypothesis’ has the obvious advantage of postulating a simpler, more economical system than the one ensuing from the ‘bare *que* hypothesis,’ as the former posits one

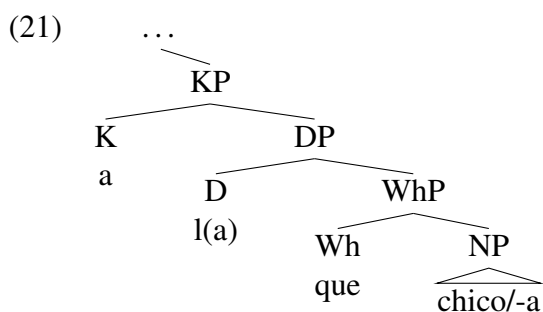
¹¹ As a matter of fact, Poletto & Sanfelici (2018) claim that there are reasons to believe that the dichotomy between relativisers and relative pronouns is not as clear-cut as originally thought. I will come back on this below and show that my proposal follows the very direction taken by Poletto & Sanfelici (2018).

¹² The discussion of this (counter-)argument is far beyond the scope of this paper, and so is the detailed examination of Brucart’s and Suñer’s complete proposals, for which I refer directly to the cited sources and to Perpiñán’s (2010:49-56) review of the topic.

single *que* in the lexicon. At the same time, however, treating *que* as a C-head leaves open the question of why it shares all the relevant properties of relative pronouns (see above). It thus seems that neither accounts is, on the whole, fully exempt from criticism. On closer look, though, there still remains a third possibility to explore: we could say that *que* is always a wh-word. This way, the desired simplicity of Brucart's analysis is preserved and, at the same time, we can better account for the similarities between *que* and relative pronouns. This is the core of my proposal, which I will elucidate in the next section.

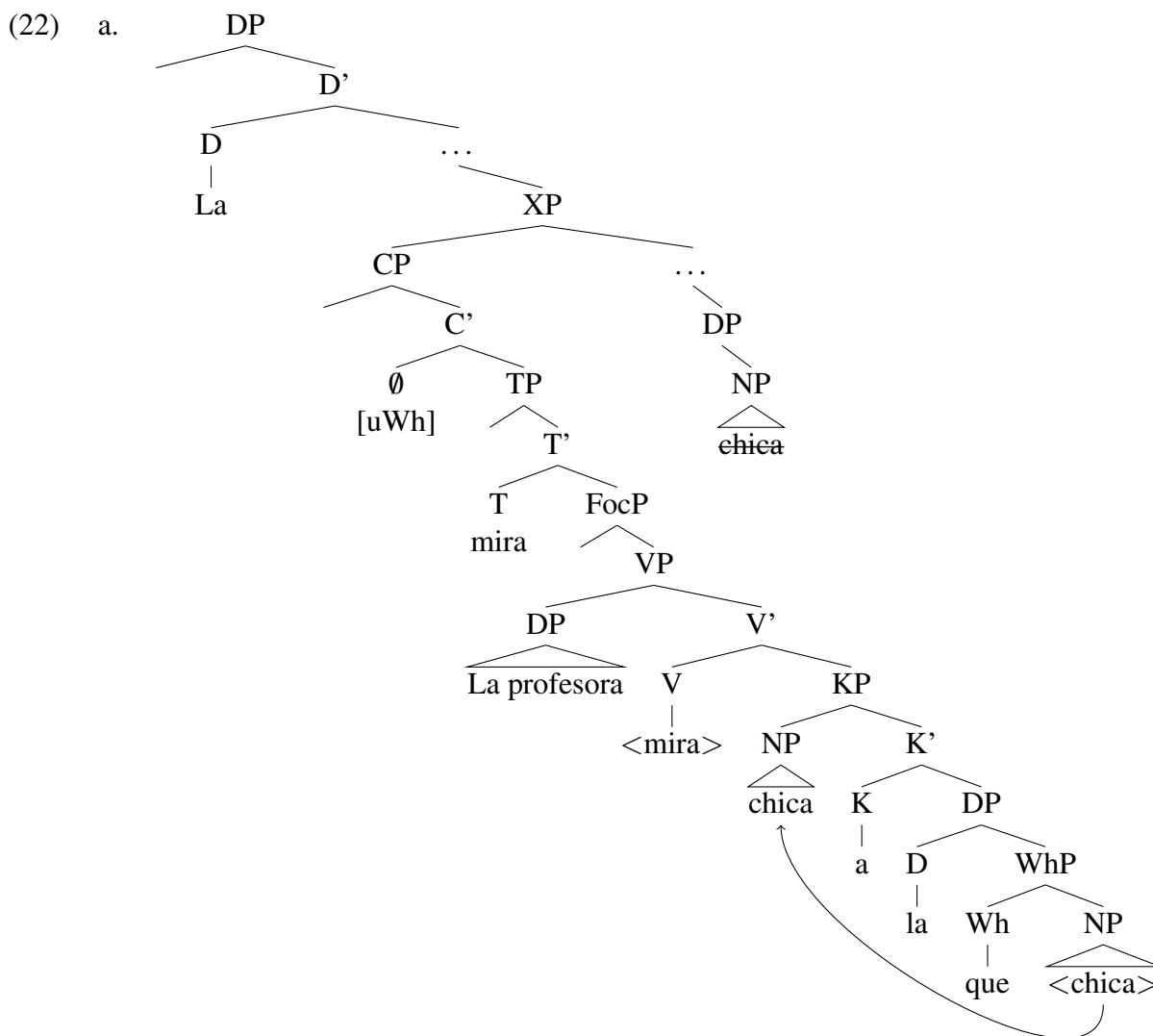
5. The proposal: *que* as a wh-word

In essence, I propose that Spanish *que* be analysed as a wh-word, and not as a complementiser. This is perfectly in line with a number of well-established analyses of *que*'s counterparts in other Romance languages. Indeed, that RCs are always introduced by a wh-word has been proposed for Italian (Manzini & Savoia 2003, 2011; Poletto & Sanfelici 2018; Rugna 2023), old and modern Italo-Romance dialects (Poletto & Sanfelici 2018, 2019), French (Rooryck 2000; Sportiche 2011), European Portuguese (Rinke & Aßmann 2017), Brazilian Portuguese (Kato & Nunes 2009). All these accounts can be somehow connected with Kayne's (2008; 2014) claim that there is no real distinction between complementisers and relative pronouns, as the former do not exist and all relative particles are in fact determiners. Based upon such a theoretical stance, Poletto & Sanfelici (2018) maintain that *che* (and its variations) in the Italo-Romance system is always a determiner-like element that bears (at least) a [Wh] feature and has the lexical property of requiring a nominal restriction. I here extend this proposal to Spanish and contend that *que* is a wh-item that merges as a specifier of the internal head's NP. More in detail, I propose that *que* realises a [Wh] feature and is topped by a DP and a KP whose heads are realised by, respectively, the definite article *el/la* and the A-marker *a* (I henceforth refer to this configuration as A + L *que*), as represented in (21).



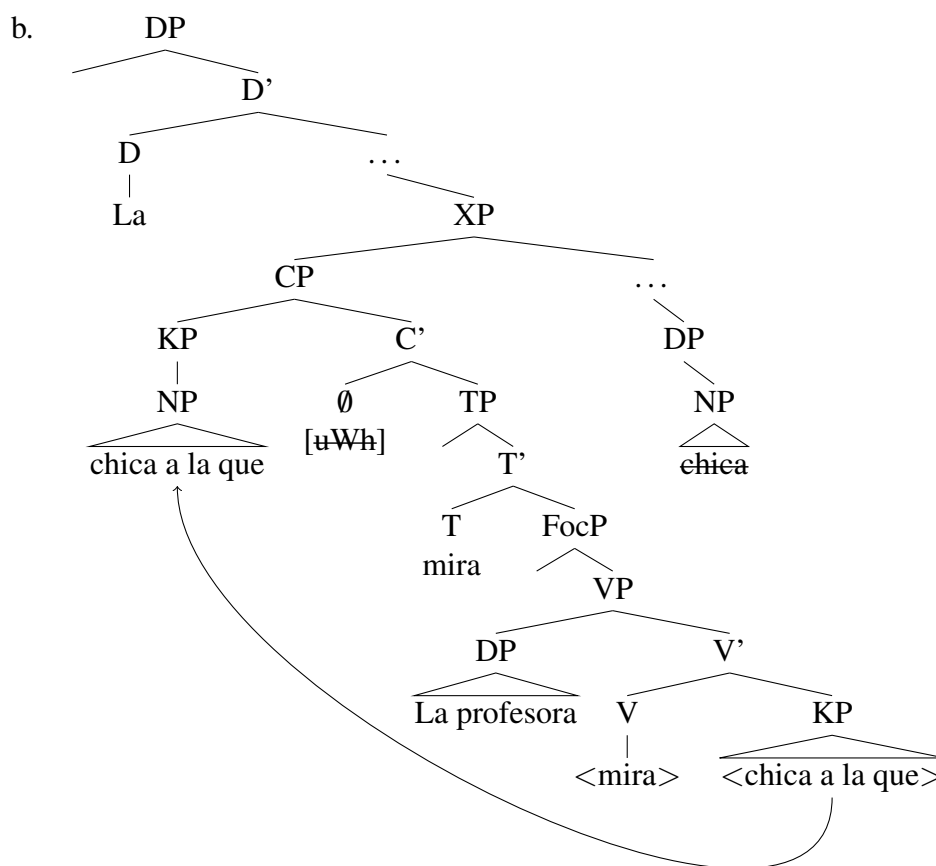
As far as the derivation of the entire RC is concerned, I propose that it proceeds in a raising fashion, with the internal head of a Cinque-style double-headed structure raising to Spec,CP (cf. 6). However, I here adopt an analysis closer to the one proposed by Poletto & Sanfelici (2018), which differs from Cinque's in a few aspects. First, their RC is a CP and not an IP (like in Rizzi 1997 and Bianchi 1999). As already mentioned, moreover, they claim that a wh-element (here *que*) modifies the internal head, similarly to what Kayne (1994) originally proposed for which-relatives. This way, the derivations of which-relatives and that-relatives are evened out. Last, the initial step of Poletto & Sanfelici's (2018) derivation consists of the movement of the internal-head's NP to the specifier of its dominating DP (here KP), to escape binding of the wh-

variable.¹³ In the case of Spanish ORCs like (14), then, the derivation proceeds as in (22): the internal-head's NP *chica* moves to Spec,KP to c-command the WhP (22a). Then the entire KP is attracted to Spec,CP to check against a [uWh] feature in C (22b). Finally, the external-head is deleted under (kaynean) c-command and non-distinctness, *a la* Sauerland (2003, 2004).¹⁴



¹³ The rationale underlying this claim is based upon the different semantics of the nominal expression in wh-questions and RCs. In the former, the NP introduces a variable in an open set, while in RC-contexts the NP introduces a fixed referent. As such, the nominal expression in RCs needs to reach a position that is generally occupied by (in)definite articles and encodes the presupposition of existence (Poletto & Sanfelici 2018:287).

¹⁴ Under Kayne's antisymmetric c-command based on categories, and not segments, the NP in question can c-command the lower external-head as the former is in the specifier of the phrase which is, in turn, the specifier of the CP.



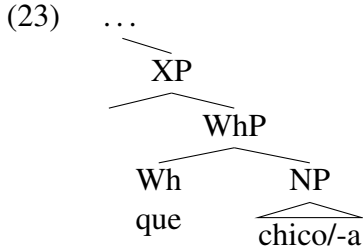
The decision to endorse a raising analysis for Spanish ORCs is mostly driven by the fact that this is, I believe, the type of derivation that better accounts for intervention effects. In (22), the copy of *chica* that is eventually realised is the one that directly crosses over the subject of the RC and hence triggers the disruption predicted by Relativised Minimality principles (Rizzi 1990, 2004, 2013a; Friedmann et al. 2009).¹⁵ If we want to construe these effects syntactically, this looks like the most reasonable analysis, although one could handle these facts even with a matching approach.¹⁶

¹⁵ In brief, the fact that the object crosses over the subject is what should make ORCs more costly than SRCs, an asymmetry that has long been acknowledged across different languages and populations (see Lau & Tanaka 2021 for an overview). This has been confirmed for Spanish with both child (Presotto & Torregrossa 2024) and adult (Presotto & Torregrossa, in prep.) populations. See also Presotto (2024) for further insights on these aspects.

¹⁶ As discussed above, the literature has reached a fairly uniform consensus about the fact that matching and raising need not be mutually-exclusive. In the Spanish RCs at issue here, one could adopt a matching analysis without major drawbacks. After all, even if the head that gets realised in a matching derivation is the external one, the movement of the object over the subject within the RC would still be part of the derivation (cf 4, and Cinque 2020:fn.21). I do not consider this specific matter crucial for the purposes of the present paper, as nothing that is discussed here directly hinges on the choice between these alternatives. As a last note, the only analysis that would probably prove inadequate to handle Relativised Minimality effects is the head-external analysis represented in (1). In such a derivation, the object moves over an empty category, which, due to the lack of relevant features, could not trigger intervention effects, at least in Rizzian terms.

5.1. The case of covert DOM

It still remains to be explained what happens in cases like (14b), where DOM is not realised, at least overtly. There are two ways I can think of to account for this. The first one is to say that when DOM is absent it is simply because the heads that are relevant for its emergence have not been merged. This is represented in (23), where the internal-head is composed of an NP topped by the WhP hosting *que* and at least an XP (evidently different from DP, since the definite article is missing, too) to whose specifier the NP is moved (cf. fn. 13).



Alternatively, one could argue that KP and DP are always realised as in (21) above, and that they are occupied by null elements when *que* occurs in its bare form (cf. e.g. Collins & Kayne 2023 for how to handle this formally). In fact, yet another possibility is available that I personally consider a more elegant variant of the latter, whereby *que* can alternatively spell-out its own head or the entire K-D-Wh sequence. Put differently, in this latter view there is just one type of *que* in the lexicon that is always merged as a modifier of the NP and is capable of spelling-out different portions of the structure. In one case, it realises the Wh head alone, and D and K are spelled-out one-by-one by their respective lexical items *el/la* and *a* (i.e. the definite article and the A-marker). Otherwise, *que* can spell-out also K and D. This is handled rather smoothly in any system that allows for a one-to-many mapping between lexical items and heads, as commonly described in frameworks like e.g. Nanosyntax (Starke 2009; Caha 2009a,b; Baunaz et al. 2018) and DM (Halle & Marantz 1993, 1994; Harley & Noyer 1999). Here I call upon the formal tools provided by Svenonius' theory of spanning (Svenonius 2012, 2016, 2020), which I briefly summarise in the next paragraph.

5.1.1. Spanning theory

According to Svenonius, the operation of Spell-out targets SPANS. A SPAN is defined as a syntactic head (a *trivial span*) or a sequence of syntactic heads (a *non-trivial span*) in a functional projection. That is, given an extended projection (e.g. N and all its functional heads), a span characterises as a subpart of a *complement line* that links an unbroken sequence of heads in a complement-relation. This is formally defined in (24):¹⁷

(24) *Definition of Span* (from Svenonius 2020)

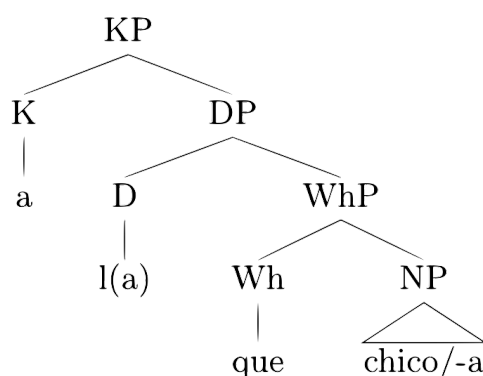
- a. A span is a head (a minimal X^0) or a sequence of heads $\langle h_1, h_2 \dots \rangle$ such that for each $n > 1$, $R_C(h_{n-1}, h_n)$ (REF svenonius 2012, merchant 2015)
- b. $R_C(h_m, h_n) = h_m$ is the head of the complement h_n

¹⁷ The definition assumes that there exists a complement relation R_C whereby each head in a functional sequence takes the immediately lower head in the sequence as a complement (cf. Grimshaw 2005). Crucially, this relation must be distinct from the relations that apply to specifiers and to adjuncts (cf. Svenonius 2020).

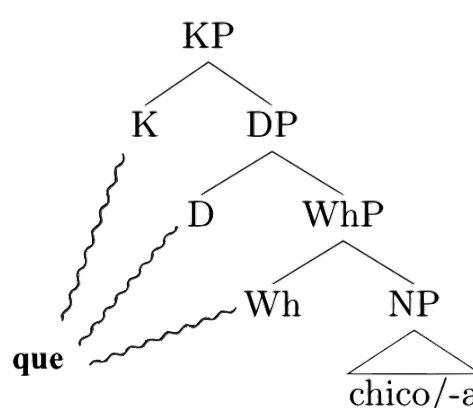
Each morphological exponent is associated with a span, be this trivial or non-trivial. This association takes place during Spell-out, defined as the operation that maps syntactic structures onto representations that serve as input to the phonological component (Chomsky 1995). Spell-out, according to Svenonius, operates cyclically (Chomsky 2000, 2001), and in a two-steps fashion.¹⁸ In a first step, called L(exical)-Match, the syntactic structure is associated with lexical entries. These, in a way, mediate the pairing between (portions of) syntactic representations and their phonological realisation. Crucially, the L-Match operation is exclusively concerned with features ‘on the syntactic side of the pairing’ (Svenonius 2012:3), as it is only in the second step of Spell-out, called Insert (Bye & Svenonius 2010, 2012), that the phonological properties of the matched exponents are interpreted.

In the case of the Spanish ORCs at issue here, L-Match has two options. As hinted at above, the lexical entry *que* can L-match either a trivial Span represented by the single Wh-head (25a), or the non-trivial Span including the sequence K-D-Wh (25b).¹⁹

(25) a. **Trivial Span L-Match**



b. **Non-trivial Span L-Match**



5.1.2. Why Spanning?

At this point, though, a crucial question legitimately arises. Is there any evidence for postulating the presence of the entire K-D-Wh sequence even when bare *que* realises? Why not saying that in such cases KP and DP are simply absent from the underlying representation (see above)? A first possible way to look at the problem is to consider the parallelism with the main clause. As mentioned earlier, it is somehow surprising that the same direct objects need to be overtly A-marked in the matrix clause but not in RC-contexts. This asymmetry becomes less perplexing if *que* is capable of realising all the relevant DOM-projections. In this scenario, the only difference between the matrix clause and RCs would be restricted to independent lexicalisation properties of *que*: DOM does not overtly surface when *que* realises the whole K-D-Wh sequence, but the underlying syntax is always the same. This is, however, hardly enough support to the span-based

¹⁸ This would be motivated by the strict modular disjunction that holds between phonology and syntax (Zwicky 1969, 1987; Zwicky & Pullum 1986). Although see Bruening (2018, 2019) and Richards (2010, 2016) for perspectives rejecting the hypothesis of a Phonology-free-Syntax.

¹⁹ The representations in (25) are probably a simplification, as it might be more accurate to distinguish two different lexical entries for *que*: one endowed with [K-D-Wh] features and the other only with [Wh]. This does not affect the core of my analysis and, in fact, the two alternatives are not necessarily mutually exclusive (Svenonius p.c.).

analysis illustrated above. One could still argue that the difference between bare *que* and A + L *que* lies with the possibility that in the former case the direct object merged in the RC need not meet DOM requirements. Put it simply, we could propose that bare *que* occurs when the direct object in the RC is not specific (or perhaps even definite), so that it does not require DOM. If that be the case, the projections responsible for A-marking (KP) and specificity/definiteness (DP) would just not be merged.²⁰ In contrast, when (animate) specific, definite direct objects are selected at the RC-level, the conditions for DOM are there, determining the need for both KP and DP (and the ensuing emergence of A + L *que*). Now, as minimal as this alternative analysis seems, it still leaves some issues unaddressed. First of all, one needs to explain why there are no interpretative differences whatsoever between ORCs featuring bare *que* vs A + L *que*. Again, sentences like (14a) and (14b), repeated in (26), are semantically equivalent.

- (26) a. la chica a la que la profesora mira
 the girl DOM the that the teacher looks
 b. la chica que la profesora mira
 the girl that the teacher looks
 ‘the girl that the teacher is looking at’

One might argue that in (26b), the interpretation of the head noun perfectly matches that of (26a) not because of an identical underlying structure, but rather because the ultimate semantics is assigned, in both cases, by the external DP, whose features override those assigned RC-internally. I believe this analysis to be neither superior nor conclusive. First, it is not the null hypothesis, it is *a* hypothesis, much as the span-based one proposed above. Moreover, there seem to exist cases where positing the absence of DOM-relevant projections in the syntactic representation is quite problematic, regardless of whether *que* appears in its bare form or is preceded by A + L. I discuss a few such examples in the following paragraph.

In his seminal monograph, López (2012) discusses cases where DOM must be obligatorily realised.²¹ In particular, beside reviewing some well-described semantic requisites of the direct object, he illustrates that there are specific syntactic configurations that impose the realisation of DOM. These include small clauses, clause union, and object control (López 2012:23-25). For instance, (27) shows that the nominal phrase in the small clause must be A-marked:

- (27) El profesor consideró a/* $\emptyset$ un estudiante inteligente
 The professor considered DOM a student intelligent
 ‘The professor considered a student intelligent’ (López 2012:(56))

Similarly, affected direct objects in clause union also require DOM. This can be seen with causative constructions like in (28), as ‘[t]he causee of an intransitive predicate is accusative [and] obligatorily introduced by accusative A’ (López 2012:23), but also with complements of perception verbs, as in (29).

- (28) María hizo llegar tarde a/* $\emptyset$ un niño
 María made arrive late DOM a boy

²⁰ For a similar idea, see Cinque (2020:15-19), where the RC-internal head is described as a dP rather than a full DP.

²¹ Lopez only takes into account indefinite objects, while I am considering definite ones. Nonetheless, whenever DOM is obligatory with indefinites, it is *a fortiori* obligatory with definites, the latter being evidently higher in the definite scale (Aissen 2003).

‘María made a boy be late’

(López 2012:(58))

(29) María vio caer a/*Ø un niño

María saw fall DOM a boy

‘María saw a boy fall’

(López 2012:(64))

In all these (and similar) contexts, DOM cannot be omitted. What makes these cases particularly interesting for the present discussion is the fact that the conditions imposing the A-marker are strictly syntactic and have nothing to do with the specificity of the marked objects, as demonstrated by the fact that these can be naturally interpreted as non-specific (López 2012:25). Thus, if we embed the above examples into a RC-structure, we expect the very same conditions to apply, independently of the semantic contribution of the external D-head. That is, because the A-marking is imposed by the argument-structure of the RC-internal predicate, potential interactions with the definiteness/specificity features of the external DP will not affect the realisation of DOM. This means that the projections relevant for DOM (here described as the K-D sequence) must be there. How is this relevant? Well, if *que* can introduce these types of RCs, then we do have some evidence in support of the span approach advanced above. Let us see the relevant examples. The sentences in (30) reproduce the case of small-clause complements illustrated in (27). A + L *que* is perfectly fine and, in fact, seems to be the more natural form to use. Albeit probably more marginal, however, also bare *que* can fit this context.

(30) a. Un estudiante al que considero inteligente fue admitido en Oxford.

a student DOM.the that consider.1sg intelligent was admitted in Oxford

‘A student I consider intelligent was admitted to Oxford.’

b. ? Un estudiante que considero inteligente fue admitido en Oxford.

a student that consider.1sg intelligent was admitted in Oxford

‘A student I consider intelligent was admitted to Oxford.’

The same holds true for (31) and (32), which reflect their matrix-counterparts (reported in 28 and 29). Again, even though A + L *que* is preferred here, too, bare *que* remains a viable option, at least in some speakers’ grammar.²²

(31) a. El chico al que María hizo llegar tarde se llama Juan.

the boy DOM.the that María made arrive late REFL call Juan

‘The boy Maria made late is called Juan.’

b. ? El chico que María hizo llegar tarde se llama Juan.

the boy that María made arrive late REFL call Juan

‘The boy Maria made late is called Juan.’

(32) a. El niño al que María vio caer se hizo daño.

the child DOM.the that María saw fall REFL made damage

‘The child that Mary saw fall hurt himself.’

²² It would be interesting to run a controlled study to gauge the extent to which these sentences are accepted across participants and in different sentences. Due to space and time restrictions, I had to limit myself to collect judgements through an online form. Twenty native speakers (most of which were linguists) completed the forms and gave various answers. In the sentences displaying bare *que* reported here, at least 50% of my informants considered the sentences acceptable. As always when DOM is concerned, I suspect there is much variability depending on (sub-)regional varieties.

- b. ? El niño que María vio caer se hizo daño.
 the child that María saw fall REFL made damage
 ‘The child that Mary saw fall hurt himself.’

If we were to believe that bare *que* can only realise (the head of) WhP, the acceptability of (30b, 31b, 32b) would escape an immediate explanation. On the contrary, if the Span account defended here is on the right track, these facts are actually predicted: DOM is always represented at the syntactic level, it simply does not surface with its typical *a* morpheme whenever *que* realises the entire K-D-Wh span. This is not to say that this is necessarily the case. I am only suggesting that *que* (in its bare form) *can* realise DOM, but need not to. It is thus possible that bare *que* also serves all cases where the direct object internal to the RC need/must not be introduced by DOM.

That an alternation between different exponents in syntactically equivalent environments exists should not sound too surprising. Similar cases can be found elsewhere in the Romance domain, confirming that this is indeed an option available to grammars. Take the case of Italian *cui* ‘to whom’. *Cui* is a relative element introducing indirect object RCs. Interestingly, it can occur either alone or preceded by the dative preposition *a*.

- (33) a. La professoressa cui devo consegnare la tesi è in ferie.
 the professor that-DAT must.1SG submit the thesis is in holiday
 ‘The professor to whom I have to hand in my thesis is on holiday.’
 b. La professoressa a cui devo consegnare la tesi è in ferie.
 the professor to that-DAT must.1SG submit the thesis is in holiday
 ‘The professor to whom I have to hand in my thesis is on holiday.’

The use of either form has no reflexes in the interpretation, as both *cui* and *a cui* unquestionably bear dative case in the given examples.²³ Once again then, we are looking at an example in which two different morphological exponents presuppose the same underlying syntax, and one of these exponents is morphologically richer. Although there is probably more than one way to modulate this alternation, Spans seem to offer a particularly agile account. In (33a), *cui* realises a K-Wh span, while in (33b) K is realised by the dative marker *a* and Wh by *cui*, in the exact same fashion discussed for Spanish (A + L) *que*.

6. Summary and conclusions

This paper focuses on restrictive SRCs and ORCs in Spanish. The literature on the syntax of these structures offers a host of different analyses, sometimes differing in only a few marginal aspects. After evaluating the alternatives, I decided to implement a raising approach based on Cinque’s double-headed RC-structure, whereby the internal-head raises to a position c-commanding the external-head and deletes it. As mentioned, however, I do not exclude that other analyses (notably a matching derivation) can equally serve the purpose.

A second important aspect that was taken into account is the categorial status of *que*. Again, there is a vast literature discussing the nature of relative elements, and at the centre of the

²³ The only difference between the two forms can be related to their register. *Cui* is more likely used in a higher diaphasic context, while *a cui* is preferable in every-day speech. Interestingly, some Spanish speakers have very similar intuitions and reported that A + L *que* might sound more formal than bare *que*.

debate is the question about whether and when these should be considered complementisers or wh-words. I argue that Spanish *que* is always a wh-word that merges as a modifier of the NP in the internal-head position, extending to Spanish the (by now standard) analysis adopted for most Romance languages.

Last, I considered the variability in the surface forms of ORCs in Spanish. Without affecting the interpretation, these can vary along two dimensions, namely the position of the subject within the RC and the realisation of overt DOM in front of the relative element *que*. As far as word order is concerned, I followed work by Gutiérrez-Bravo (2005) and argued that the preference for a pre- or post-verbal subject is likely determined by independent phonological conditions. At the syntactic level, I represent pre-verbal subjects in the specifier of TP, and post-verbal subjects in the specifiers of a low FocusP, as is standardly assumed. Accounting for the alternation between bare *que* and A + L *que* is less immediate, however. Also in this case the interpretation is not affected, but the question of what constitutes the underlying syntax of the two forms remains a complex one. I propose that the syntactic representation need not be different, and that both *que* and A + L *que* can realise the same structural portions, crucially including the projections that are relevant for DOM. I modulate this adopting Svenonius' theory of spanning, whereby single lexical entries can realise sequences of heads of different sizes. In the case in question, *que* solely realises a Wh head when it is preceded by *al/a la* (i.e. A + L, which realise respectively a K head and a D head), and the full K-D-Wh sequence when it occurs in its bare form.

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